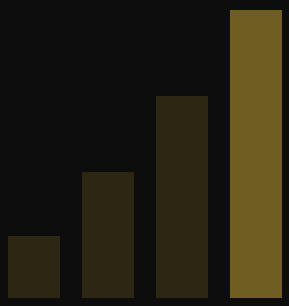
P2SEC

2027 EDITION · FREE GUIDE

The 2027 Cyber Cert Roadmap

Which certification you get first, what order to take the rest in, and the job each one actually leads to.



Written by a working cybersecurity professional

Facts verified 9 November 2026 against official certifying-body sources

Built for career changers and absolute beginners

START HERE

The 30-second version.

You do not need every certification. You need the right three, in the right order, with a job title in mind. This page is the whole guide in one screen. Everything after it is the detail.

STEP 0 · OPTIONAL
Network+
Only if networking is completely foreign to you. If you already troubleshoot networks, skip it.

STEP 1 · THE ANCHOR
Security+
Every track on this page starts here. It is the common requirement across all four job families.

STEP 2 · CHOOSE
One track
Pick by the job you want, not by the certification that sounds most exciting.

STEP 3 · GO DEEPER
Specialize
Add the cert that changes your title, or step up to the capstone when you already do the work.

TRACK 01 · THE DEFENDER
SOC Analyst
Security+ → CySA+ → SecAI+
Highest-volume entry path. Detection, triage, incident response.

TRACK 02 · THE ATTACKER
Junior Penetration Tester
Security+ → PenTest+
Not an entry-level cert. Usually a second job, not a first one.

TRACK 03 · THE CLOUD
Cloud Security Analyst
Security+ → AWS Cloud Practitioner → Solutions Architect Associate → Security Specialty

TRACK 04 · THE IDENTITY
IAM Analyst
Security+ → SC-300 or **Okta Certified Professional → SailPoint**
Less competition, central to zero trust.

IF YOU ONLY DO ONE THING THIS YEAR

Earn Security+ and finish two lab projects you can actually explain out loud. The certification gets you the interview. The projects get you the offer.

HOW TO READ THE LABELS IN THIS GUIDE

FACT exam code, length, passing score, recommended experience, renewal rule. Read from the certifying body's own site, verified 9 November 2026. RECOMMENDATION the order, the track, when to book. That is judgement, not fact.

Exam versions, prices, and renewal rules change without notice. Everything on these pages is accurate as of 9 November 2026. Confirm on the certifying body's own site before you spend money or book a date.

STEP 1 · EVERYONE STARTS HERE

CompTIA Security+

The one certification that appears as a baseline requirement in defensive, offensive, cloud, and identity job postings. Earn it before anything else on this list.

FACT Verified 9 November 2026

CURRENT EXAM	SY0-801 (V8)
LAUNCH DATE	Expected November 17, 2026
QUESTIONS	Maximum 90, multiple choice and performance based
DURATION	90 minutes
PASSING SCORE	750 on a scale of 100 to 900
FORMAL PREREQUISITE	None listed by CompTIA
RECOMMENDED	Security administrator with two years of hands-on experience
VALIDITY	Three years from the date earned
RENEWAL	Continuing education through CompTIA's CE program, or a qualifying higher-level cert

LEADS TO THESE ROLES

SOC Analyst I · Security Administrator · IT Security Specialist · Junior Systems Administrator

WHY IT IS FIRST

It is the credential that makes a career changer look like a security hire instead of an IT hire. Every track in this guide builds on it, and none of the advanced certs on this list replace it.

RECOMMENDATION · SIT SY0-801

CompTIA retires the previous English version a few months after a new version launches. Confirm the exact SY0-701 retirement date on comptia.org. If you plan to test in the second half of 2027, study the V8 objectives from day one instead of switching versions mid-prep.

RECOMMENDATION

Plan for 8 to 12 weeks

At 8 to 10 hours a week if security is new to you. Faster if you already work in IT and just need the vocabulary and the exam format.

Skip what you already know

If you already fix computers for a living, do not go backwards to an IT support certification. Go straight at the security exam and use the objectives as your syllabus.

FACT What the V8 exam covers, per CompTIA

- Layered security controls, Zero Trust principles, access management, and cryptography
- Threat actors, attack techniques, vulnerabilities, and indicators of malicious activity, including AI-related risks
- Protecting cloud, hybrid, on-premises, and connected environments
- Monitoring, vulnerability management, security tools, automation, and operational security
- Authentication, authorization, federation, multifactor authentication, and access control
- Detecting, responding to, and investigating incidents using logs, alerts, and security data
- Security policy, risk management, compliance, audit concepts, and awareness programs
- Supporting resilience and business continuity

TRACK 01 · THE DEFENDER

The SOC analyst path.

The highest-volume entry into cybersecurity. Most people who say they want to get into security end up here first, because every organization with a security team needs someone watching alerts.

THIS TRACK LEADS TO

SOC Analyst Tier 1 | Cyber Defense Analyst | Incident Response Analyst | Security Administrator

CompTIA CySA+

FACT Verified 9 November 2026

EXAM	CS0-004 (V4), launched June 23, 2026
QUESTIONS	Maximum 85
DURATION	165 minutes
PASSING SCORE	750 on a scale of 100 to 900
RECOMMENDED	About four years as a SOC analyst or vulnerability analyst
RENEWAL	Three years, renewed through CompTIA CE

CySA+ is the certification hiring managers read as **this person can work a detection queue, triage an alert, and write it up.** It is the natural second step after Security+ and the thing that separates a candidate from a stack of identical Security+ resumes.

RECOMMENDATION

Do not wait for four years of experience before sitting it. The recommended experience describes the job you are targeting, not a gate. Six to twelve months of real exposure plus serious lab work is enough to prepare honestly.

CompTIA SecAI+

FACT New in 2026

EXAM	CY0-001 (V1), launched February 17, 2026
QUESTIONS	Maximum 60
DURATION	60 minutes
PASSING SCORE	600 on a scale of 100 to 900
RECOMMENDED	Three to four years in IT, two or more in security
RENEWAL	Three years, renewed through CompTIA CE

Security operations is being rebuilt around AI-assisted detection, and this is the first CompTIA certification aimed directly at securing AI systems and using AI inside security operations. It is new, so it is not yet a common job requirement. It is a differentiator, not a ticket.

RECOMMENDATION

Treat SecAI+ as your third cert if you are aiming at a modern SOC or detection engineering role. Skip it if you have not worked a queue yet.

Capstone, not a starting point: CompTIA SecurityX, exam CAS-005, is the rebranded CASP+ and recommends ten years of IT experience including five in security. Put it on the five-year horizon.

TRACK 02 · THE ATTACKER

The offensive security path.

The most popular track to ask about and the hardest one to enter. Read this page before you buy anything.

THIS TRACK LEADS TO

Vulnerability Analyst | Junior Penetration Tester | Security Consultant | Application Security Analyst

CompTIA PenTest+

FACT Verified 9 November 2026

EXAM	PT0-003 (V3), launched December 17, 2024
QUESTIONS	Maximum 90, multiple choice and performance based
DURATION	165 minutes
PASSING SCORE	750 on a scale of 100 to 900
RECOMMENDED	Three to four years in a penetration testing role, with Network+ and Security+ knowledge
RENEWAL	Three years, renewed through CompTIA CE

VERSION CHECK BEFORE YOU BOOK

CompTIA states that PenTest+ exams usually retire about three years after launch, which puts a replacement around 2027. Confirm the live exam code on comptia.org before buying a voucher.

RECOMMENDATION · NOT AN ENTRY-LEVEL CERT

Offensive work is a second job, not a first one. The people who get hired as junior testers usually arrive from a SOC, systems administration, or development background, because a tester who cannot explain how a defender sees an attack is not useful on an engagement.

If offensive security is the goal: Security+ first, then two years in a defensive or infrastructure role while you build a public lab portfolio, then PenTest+. That sequence is slower and it is what actually converts.

WHAT MATTERS MORE THAN THE BADGE

- Report writing that a non-technical executive can act on
- One repeatable methodology, practiced end to end
- One deep specialization: web applications, Active Directory, or cloud

THE REALISTIC SEQUENCE

01 Security+ → 02 SOC or sysadmin role → 03 PenTest+ → 04 Junior tester

Every year, thousands of people pay for an offensive certification before they have ever worked a ticket or read a log. The certification is real. The job market for people who hold only the certification is not what they were promised.

TRACK 03 · THE CLOUD

The cloud security path.

The highest-paying of the four tracks, and the one where a certification alone moves your resume fastest, because the work is tied to a specific platform.

THIS TRACK LEADS TO

Cloud Support Associate | Cloud Security Analyst | Cloud Security Engineer | DevSecOps Support

FACT All three verified on aws.amazon.com, November 2026

AWS CERTIFICATION	LEVEL	FEE	EXAM	RECOMMENDED EXPERIENCE
Cloud Practitioner CLF-C02	Foundational	100 USD	65 questions 90 minutes	Up to six months of AWS exposure. Built for people with no prior IT or cloud background.
Solutions Architect – Associate SAA-C03	Associate	150 USD	65 questions 130 minutes	At least one year of hands-on experience designing cloud solutions on AWS.
Security – Specialty SCS-C03	Specialty	300 USD	65 questions 170 minutes	Five years of IT security experience and two or more years securing AWS workloads.

All three certifications are valid for three years. AWS recertifies by passing the latest version of the exam.

Why the order matters

For a security career, the useful sequence is Cloud Practitioner, then Solutions Architect Associate, then Security Specialty. Security Specialty is the one that changes your title, but it assumes you can already design in AWS. The associate exam is what forces you to learn that.

Two facts worth knowing

Once you hold one active AWS Certification, AWS gives you a **50 percent discount** on your next AWS exam. And Cloud Practitioner is explicitly designed as an entry point for people switching from a non-technical background.

RECOMMENDATION

Cloud plus Security+ beats five vendor-neutral certificates with no cloud exposure. Pick one cloud and go deep, because the hiring manager is checking whether you can operate in their platform, not whether you collected badges.

If you are choosing between this track and the SOC track, choose based on the job postings in your city. Cloud roles are less numerous and better paid. SOC roles are more numerous and easier to enter.

DO THE MATH ON THIS TRACK

The three exams total **550 USD** at list price. AWS then discounts your next exam by 50 percent once you are certified, which brings the three to about **325 USD**.

ONE CLOUD, NOT THREE

Employers hire for the platform they run. Learning the concepts on a second cloud is cheap and worth doing later. Paying for a second cloud's certification before you have a cloud job is not.

TRACK 04 · THE IDENTITY

The identity and access path.

The quiet track. Less competition than SOC work, central to every zero trust program, and it rewards people who like process, data, and access reviews.

THIS TRACK LEADS TO

IAM Analyst | Identity and Access Administrator | IAM Engineer | SailPoint or Okta Administrator

Microsoft SC-300

PRICE BY REGION

Identity and Access Administrator Associate. Intermediate level, focused on Microsoft Entra ID, hybrid identity, and identity governance. Microsoft renews this certification **every 12 months** through an online assessment, with no exam retake. Exam price is set by country and region.

RECOMMENDATION

The strongest single IAM credential if your target employers run Microsoft 365 and Entra. It is the most common identity requirement you will see in job posts.

Okta Certified Professional

250 USD

First attempt is **250 USD**. Okta lists no formal prerequisite for the Professional exam. Certification is valid for two years. Administrator requires Professional first.

RECOMMENDATION

Worth it when the companies you want use Okta for workforce identity. It is a platform credential, so it pays off when the job posting names the platform.

SailPoint certifications

SEE SAILPOINT

Role-based certifications from SailPoint University, including Identity Security Administrator and IdentityIQ Engineer. SailPoint publishes the current fee and recommended experience for each path; confirm both on its own site before booking.

RECOMMENDATION

SailPoint is one of the largest dedicated identity governance vendors and its certifications appear directly in IAM job requirements. Best taken inside an IAM team, or after a serious lab build.

CIDPRO (IDPro)

750 USD

Certified Identity Professional. Vendor-neutral, **750 USD**, multiple-choice, delivered worldwide through IDPro's testing partner.

RECOMMENDATION

The right choice if you want one credential not tied to a single vendor, for example for identity governance, IAM program work, or consulting. It is knowledge-based, so pair it with hands-on platform work.

WHY THIS TRACK IS UNDERRATED IN 2027

Most IAM engineers learned on the job, which means a certification plus a homelab is a real opening rather than a nice-to-have. Access reviews, joiner-mover-leaver automation, and privileged access work are unglamorous, constant, and hard to outsource. That combination is what keeps this track hiring.

PUT IT IN A CALENDAR

A 12-month plan for 2027.

A recommendation, not a rule. It assumes roughly 10 hours a week and a full-time job. Move the dates; keep the order.

Q1 2027

Security+

Sit SY0-801 by the end of March. Do not start studying for a second cert before this one is passed.

Q2 2027

First track cert

CySA+, AWS Cloud Practitioner, SC-300, or Okta Certified Professional. Pick one. One.

Q3 2027

The title changer

AWS Solutions Architect Associate, Okta Administrator, CySA+ if you started elsewhere, or SailPoint if you are already in an IAM team.

Q4 2027

Specialize

SecAI+, AWS Security Specialty, PenTest+ only with real experience, or SecurityX if you already hold a senior title.

ALL YEAR · TWO LAB PROJECTS, DOCUMENTED

One detection or incident writeup. One cloud or identity build. Certifications get you the interview; the writeups get you the offer. If you cannot explain what you built and why, it does not count.

If you have zero IT experience

Get any technical job first: help desk, desktop support, or a network operations center role. Then Security+ within your first year. The certification will not compensate for having never worked a ticket, and the ticket job is what gives you the stories you will tell in interviews.

If you already work in IT

Skip the foundational certs and go straight at Security+, then pick the track closest to the team you want to transfer into. Internal moves are the least competitive route into security, and your current manager is the cheapest sponsor you will ever find.

FIVE RULES THAT DECIDE WHETHER THIS WORKS

1. **One certification at a time.** Starting three is how people finish none.
2. **Book the exam date before you feel ready.** A date creates urgency that a study plan cannot.
3. **Lab everything you read.** If you cannot show it, you do not know it.
4. **Read the official exam objectives, not just a course.** The objectives are the exam.
5. **Budget for renewal.** Every CompTIA cert on this list expires in three years and requires continuing education or a higher cert.

REFERENCE

Facts at a glance.

Every code, fee, and renewal rule below was read from the certifying body's own site on 9 November 2026. Where an official price was not published on the certification page, the table says so instead of guessing.

CERTIFICATION	EXAM CODE	EXAM FEE (USD)	VALIDITY AND RENEWAL
COMPTIA			
Network+ (optional foundation)	N10-009	Not published on cert page	3 years, CE or higher cert
Security+	SY0-801 (V8)	Not published on cert page	3 years, CE or higher cert
CySA+	CS0-004 (V4)	Not published on cert page	3 years, CE or higher cert
PenTest+	PT0-003 (V3)	Not published on cert page	3 years, CE or higher cert
SecAI+	CY0-001 (V1)	Not published on cert page	3 years, CE or higher cert
SecurityX (formerly CASP+)	CAS-005 (V5)	Not published on cert page	3 years, CE or higher cert
AMAZON WEB SERVICES			
Cloud Practitioner	CLF-C02	100	3 years, recertify by exam
Solutions Architect – Associate	SAA-C03	150	3 years, recertify by exam
Security – Specialty	SCS-C03	300	3 years, recertify by exam
IDENTITY AND ACCESS MANAGEMENT			
Microsoft Identity and Access Administrator	SC-300	Set by country and region	Renewed every 12 months by online assessment
Okta Certified Professional	Okta program	250 first attempt	2 years
Okta Certified Administrator	Okta program	250 first attempt	2 years
SailPoint Identity Security Administrator	SailPoint program	See SailPoint	See SailPoint recertification policy
SailPoint IdentityIQ Engineer	SailPoint program	See SailPoint	See SailPoint recertification policy
CIDPRO (Certified Identity Professional)	IDPro program	750	See IDPro

ON COMPTIA PRICING

CompTIA does not publish a single list price on its certification pages, and voucher prices vary with bundles, retakes, and region. Budget a few hundred US dollars per attempt and confirm the number at checkout on comptia.org. Academic pricing, exam bundles, and employer reimbursement are the three legitimate ways to reduce it.

WHAT THIS GUIDE LEAVES OUT

Course-based entry certificates and badge-style credentials. They are not worthless, but they are not what hiring managers screen on for the roles in this guide. This roadmap stays with CompTIA, AWS, and identity credentials that appear in job postings.

SOURCES USED FOR VERIFICATION

comptia.org: Security+ V8 and V7, CySA+ V4, PenTest+ V3, SecAI+ V1, SecurityX, Network+, Continuing Education
aws.amazon.com: Cloud Practitioner, Solutions Architect Associate, Security Specialty, plus the AWS exam guides
learn.microsoft.com: SC-300 certification and exam pages
okta.com and certification.okta.com: program and exam detail pages
university.sailpoint.com: professional certification program
idpro.org: CIDPRO program and FAQ
Where a fee or renewal figure could not be confirmed on an official page, the table points you to the source instead of quoting a number.

DISCLAIMER

Exam versions, prices, prerequisites, and renewal rules change without notice. Everything in this guide is accurate as of 9 November 2026. Confirm on the certifying body's own site before you spend money or book a date.